NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣10

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 1NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥J

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ Q 10 9 3 ♦ A J 10 7 ♣ A 8	
♠ 10 9 7 4 ♥ 8 7 ♦ 8 5 3 ♣ K Q 5 2	N W E S	♠ K 8 3 ♥ 5 ♦ Q 9 6 4 2 ♣ 10 9 7 3
	♠ J 6 2 ♥ A K J 6 4 2 ♦ K ♣ J 6 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♠[2]	Pass	6♥
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 3 aces

6♥ by North
Lead: ♣10

Your partnership may play that a jump to 3♥ shows a 6-card suit with slam interest, in other words, this very hand. If you do, then bid it. If you don't, use a transfer first. Let's say you bid 2♦. Partner jumps to 3♥. Now

Your partnership may play that a jump to 3♥ shows a 6-card suit with slam interest, in other words, this very hand. If you do, then bid it. If you don't, use a transfer first. Let's say you bid 2♦. Partner jumps to 3♥. Now

You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least two Aces for his strong bidding. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and this is certainly not the type of hand where asking for Aces is always helpful - what if partner shows two Aces, aren't you going to bid the slam anyway? The advantage to Blackwood here is that there is just a slim possibility that partner has only one Ace!

You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♠. Next?

Your partnership may play that a jump to 3♥ shows a 6-card suit with slam interest, in other words, this very hand. If you do, then bid it. If you don't, use a transfer first. Let's say you bid 2♦. Partner jumps to 3♥. Now You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least two Aces for his strong bidding. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and this is certainly not the type of hand where asking for Aces is always helpful - what if partner shows two Aces, aren't you going to bid the slam anyway? The advantage to Blackwood here is that there is just a slim possibility that partner has only one Ace! You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♠. Next? Three Aces. You still should stop at 6♥, based on points.

The contract would be 6♥ played by South.

North plays 6♥. East leads the ♣10. You play the ♣J, just in case East made a mistake, but West puts on the ♣Q which you take with your ♣A.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 2

The ♠ loser is deceptive. You could discard a ♠ from dummy on your ♦A, but would still have a ♠ loser if the finesse doesn't work. Still, this would be one possible plan. Can you improve on that?

Maybe you can. Look harder at the ♦s. Win the ♣A, then play to dummy's ♦K. Pull trumps (2 rounds) ending in your hand. Play your ♦A, but discard a ♣ from dummy, (the key play). Now play your ♦J, and if East plays low, discard dummy's other ♣.

You have gotten rid of the ♣ losers, but if West can win the ♦Q on this trick you will discard a ♠ on the ♦10, but will still have to try the ♠ finesse.

But, if the ♦J holds then it won't matter if the ♠ finesse works or not, you will make the slam.

Suppose when you play your ♦J East puts on the ♦Q.

Board 2
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q 9 5 ♥ K Q 8 6 3 ♦ K 6 2 ♣ A 3	
♠ K 6 3 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ Q 10 9 ♣ 8 5 4 2		♠ A J 2 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ A J 7 ♣ J 9 7 6
	♠ 10 8 7 4 ♥ J 9 ♦ 8 5 4 3 ♣ K Q 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	1NT	
All Pass			

1NT by East
Lead: ♥J

With no reason to think you could improve the contract you just pass.

The contract would be 1NT played by West.

East plays 1NT. South leads the ♥J and North plays the ♥8. Do you hold up? If so, how many times?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4

It probably makes no difference whether you hold up or not since North surely has most of the high cards. However, holding up once is a good idea because South may have a singleton ♥ and have to switch to something which helps you. South holds the first trick and plays another ♥, which you win.

You must find 4 winners. The bad news is that you must finesse both the ♦K and the ♠Q. The good news is that with North opening the bidding there is a good chance he has both of them. So, how will you manage those two finesses?

There is only one way to do it. Enter dummy with the only entry, the ♠K. Take the ♦ finesse first - play the ♦Q and unblock your ♦J when North plays low. (you could play the ♦10/♦7 combination first).

Finesse the ♦ again. If North ducks a second time you must now take the ♠ finesse while you are still in dummy. If North covers the second ♦ you win with your ♦A, return to dummy with the ♦9, and then finesse the ♠.

Having used dummy's lone entry to get there in the first place you have to make sure you take the finesse that permits you to either remain in dummy, or to return if North plays his King.

And you have to be careful to unblock so you don't inadvertently lose your place in dummy too soon.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

♠ A 7 5 3
♥ K 6
♦ Q J 5 2
♣ 10 9 3

♠ J 10 6
♥ Q J 10 9 8
♦ 8 6 3
♣ K 2



♠ Q 9 8 2
♥ 5 3 2
♦ A 9
♣ 8 7 6 4

♠ K 4
♥ A 7 4
♦ K 10 7 4
♣ A Q J 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♦
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥Q

With no 4-card Major suit you respond 2♦ to partner's Stayman bid. Partner now bids 2NT.

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With 17 points you naturally accept partner's invitation and bid 3NT.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

West's ♥Q lead presents you with an immediate decision (or two) to make.

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

You need 4 additional winners and can only establish 3 of them in ♦s. So you will have to manufacture another one from the ♣ suit as well. If you assume the ♣ finesse will fail, (and you have probably noticed that most finesses **DO** fail on these pages), that means you will lose the lead twice.

So what do you do about that ♥Q? Do you win or hold up?

You hold up, of course, to cut defensive communications when West has 5 ♥s and East has 3. West will probably play another ♥ to dummy's ♥K.

If both the ♦A and ♣K are in West's hand then you won't make this contract. He will easily establish his ♥s and have an entry to get in and cash them. If the ♦A is with West and the ♣K is with East then it doesn't matter in which order you play the suits since you will not lose the lead in ♣s. But if the ♣K is with West and the ♦A is with East then it is vital that you play ♣s first.

If you play on ♦s first, East will win the ♦A and play his last ♥, forcing out your ♥A. When West wins his ♣K he will cash 2 more ♥s.

But, if you finesse in ♣s first, West can win and establish the ♥ suit. But, when East wins the ♦A, he will have no ♥ to return.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 9 8 4 ♥ 10 4 ♦ 8 7 5 2 ♣ Q 10 3	
♠ J 5 ♥ A 9 7 3 ♦ K 6 4 ♣ A K 6 2	N W E S	♠ A K 7 3 ♥ K J 8 2 ♦ A Q J ♣ 9 8
	♠ Q 6 2 ♥ Q 6 5 ♦ 10 9 3 ♣ J 7 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1NT	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	4NT[1]	Pass
5♥[2]	Pass	6♥	
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♥ by West
Lead: ♠10

Did you consider bidding 6NT? You are balanced, and the points are right. But with two 4-card Majors you should use Stayman, so you bid 2♣. Partner bids 2♥. Now what do say next?

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You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least one Ace for his 1NT opening. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and while you don't like to use Blackwood when you have a worthless doubleton, this bid will at least keep you out of slam if partner has ZERO Aces. You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♥. Next?

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You might just go ahead and bid 6♥. Partner probably has at least one Ace for his 1NT opening. The other choice is a Blackwood 4NT, and while you don't like to use Blackwood when you have a worthless doubleton, this bid will at least keep you out of slam if partner has ZERO Aces. You bid 4NT and partner replies 5♥. Next?

He has two Aces so you bid 6♥ because you know there aren't enough points for seven.

The contract would be 6♥ played by East.

West plays 6♥. North leads the ♠10.

You toy with the idea of letting this ride to your ♠J, then you put away your childish toys and play the ♠A from dummy.

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

The two ♣ losers can be ruffed in dummy. A successful ♥ finesse could save you a loser in trumps. So, should you take the ♥ finesse now?

No, because if you play ♥A, then the ♥ finesse **LOSES**, South might play a third ♥ and stop you from your two ruffs in dummy. A much better plan is to play the ♥K, then ♥A, and if the ♥Q drops, well and good. This time she doesn't, but both South and North follow to both trump leads. Play the ♣ A K, the ♠K, and the ♦ A K Q.

If somebody ruffs any of these it will be with the master trump and you won't care. But if they don't ruff yet, you just start cross-ruffing ♣s and ♠s and let them ruff in whenever they like.

Missing 5 trumps to the Queen the correct play to avoid a loser is to finesse.

But that is only correct as far as that suit is concerned. When you look at the entire hand you may find that by